



Systems Thinking for SDG Implementation

Seeing how everything connects in real life

Presented by

Adetoro Adetayo

Sustainability and Impact Strategist

Systems Thinking Session

Why talk about "systems" at all?

Because real life doesn't happen in **SDG 1** or **SDG 13** alone.

It happens where many goals meet — in our **streets**, **homes**, **schools**, and **markets**.

“ Most people don't wake up thinking: 'Today I'll work on SDG 11.' We wake up thinking about: **NEPA, transport, food, money, safety, school, health.**

By the end of this session, you will:

1

See connections

View community problems as connected, not isolated

2

Learn to map

A simple way to map those connections

3

Design better

Use that map to design better SDG projects

A day in the life of one young person

Follow one day. Count how many SDGs show up.



Morning

Wakes up sweating because power was out all night. Small petrol generator running.

SDGs touched:



Water

Buys two sachets of water on her way out, because tap water isn't safe to drink.

SDGs touched:



Transport

Takes a danfo through traffic, breathing exhaust fumes and bad air.

SDGs touched:



Food & Work

Eats cheap street food, because that's what she can afford. She spends hours in front of a computer or at a market stall.

SDGs touched:



In just one day, her life has touched **8–10 goals**.

Systems thinking respects this reality

What do we mean by a "system"?

A system is a group of things that work together so strongly that **you can't change one without touching the others**.

🍴 **The Jollof Analogy:** A pot of jollof rice $\neq$ just rice. It's **heat + pot + oil + tomatoes + time + attention**.

Heat in Lagos is not just the sun:

🏠 Concrete and asphalt

🌲 Loss of trees

🚗 Traffic and exhaust

⚡ Generators humming

🏢 Building design

🏠 Where communities are



“ If you only look at the rice, you'll never understand why the food tastes good or bad.

The SDGs are a web, not a to-do list

One action can move many goals forward or backward

SDG Interconnection Web



A Example: Building a New Road (SDG 9)

Positive impacts:

- ✓ Better access to schools (SDG 4)
- ✓ Improved market access (SDG 8)

Potential harms:

- × Tree removal increases heat (SDG 13)
- × More flooding risk (SDG 11, 15)

The Better Question

Instead of "Is this project good or bad?" ask:

- Where does it help?
- Where might it harm?
- How do we design for maximum support?

Case Story 1

Same litre, different footprint

What systems thinking found in Lagos water packaging

The Susbridge Study Finding

Full lifecycle assessment of **sachet water vs PET bottles** in Lagos

Sachet Water

$\frac{1}{2}$

the climate footprint

VS

PET Bottles

$2\times$

higher emissions

⚠️ **But:** Sachets create visible waste and pollution — a different problem

Systems Thinking Insight

Policy debates that only look at litter and say "ban sachets" are **incomplete**. If you ignore manufacturing emissions, transport, and energy use, you might **shift the problem instead of solving it**.



Better Questions to Ask

- 1 How do we improve collection & recycling?
SDG 11, 12
- 2 How do we reduce packaging weight?
SDG 9, 12
- 3 How do we guarantee safe piped water?
SDG 6, 3, 10

Urban Climate Signals

Turning heat into decisions — a dashboard for Lagos

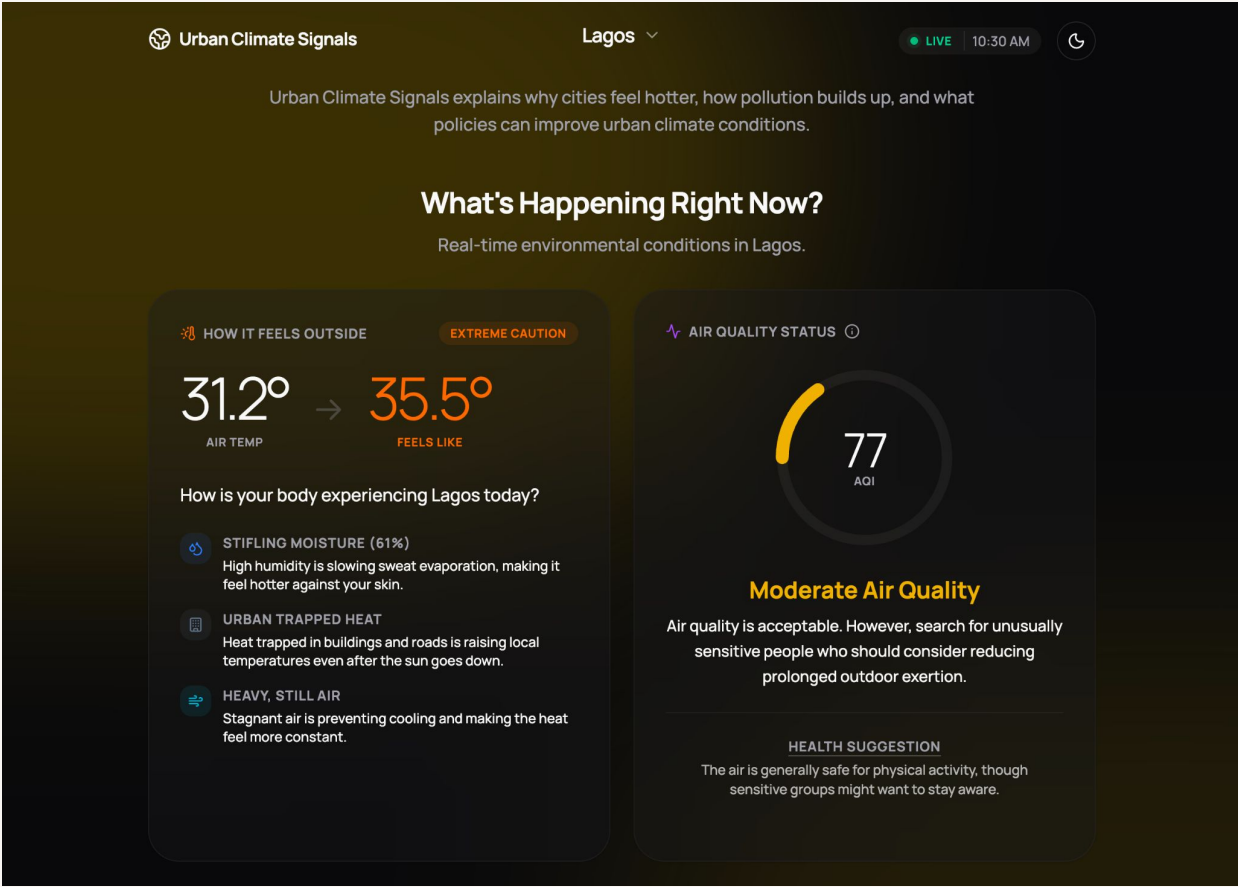
The Starting Question

"If Lagos feels this hot and this polluted **today**, what exactly is driving it, and what could leaders do **tomorrow morning** differently?"

Built at **Susbridge** — using atmospheric models and city-level data

What the Dashboard Shows

-  **Real-time heat index**
Live temperature data across neighborhoods
-  **Air quality monitoring**
Pollution levels and sources
-  **Policy simulator**
Test interventions before implementing



<https://urbanclimate.vercel.app>

Policy Simulator: Test These Levers

-  **Add green spaces**
-  **Reduce generators**
-  **More public transport usage**

A simple method you can use anywhere

1 Name the issue

State it in **plain language** that anyone can understand. No jargon.

Example: "Many young people can't find decent work, even with skills"

2 Map who & what

Identify **people, systems, and SDGs** involved. Look widely.

People → Businesses → Government →
Education → Transport → Energy

3 Trace effects

Ask: "**If this, then what?**" Follow the chain of consequences.

No power → generators → higher costs →
fewer jobs → more informal work

4 Choose entry points

Find **smarter starting points** that influence the whole system.

Not just "teach CV writing" — try
solar-powered workspaces or transport
support

💡 Example: Youth Unemployment

Surface-level solution:

"Teach CV writing" — only touches SDG 8 superficially

Systems-informed solution:

- ✓ Solar-powered study/work spaces
- ✓ Transport support for interviews
- ✓ Youth apprenticeship pathways

Same problem, **different quality of solution** — because you've respected the system around it.

Pick one issue, map 2-3 SDGs

Choose ONE real issue from your community

 Flooding after rain

 Girls dropping out

 Open burning of waste

 Insecurity at night

 Lack of safe transport

 Unreliable electricity

 **Take 2 minutes.** Write in your notebook or chat. Don't worry about "perfect" SDG numbers. The goal is to **start seeing connections**.

Ask Three Questions

1

Who is affected?

First and hardest — who feels this issue most?

2

What parts of life?

Money, health, time, safety, dignity — what does it touch?

3

Which 2-3 SDGs?

What goals show up when you look at this issue?

Sustainability is everything, not just 'green projects'

Sustainability shows up in the everyday moments of our lives



Clothes

Cheap clothes that tear quickly and end up in dumpsites

SDGs touched:



Food

Tomatoes wasted on highways because of lack of cold storage

SDGs touched:



Transport

BRT, okada bans, keke routes — decisions about who can move where

SDGs touched:



The air we breathe



The water we drink



The food we eat



The point: When you choose a project, even a small one, you're stepping into a living system of **food, land, labour, culture, and power**. Seeing that clearly is your advantage.

What happens when we ignore the system?

Three common traps to avoid



Quick Fixes

Move the problem somewhere else

Banning a product without improving alternatives. People switch to something worse or go informal.

❗ **Example:** Banning sachets without safe piped water



Report Projects

Look good, but don't last

Beautiful pilots with no plan for who maintains it, who pays after donors leave, or how it fits local policy.

❗ **Example:** Solar panels with no maintenance plan



Ignoring People

Solutions that ignore those most affected

Designing waste projects without asking women who manage household waste.

❗ **Example:** Water projects without talking to those who fetch water at 5am

? Systems Thinking Forces You to Ask:



Who wins?



Who loses?



What happens after year one?

How this connects to the rest of the programme

Systems thinking is not a one-off theory session

2

Week 2: Climate & Community Projects

Ask better questions about **trade-offs and co-benefits** when designing climate interventions

3

Week 3: Storytelling & Leadership

Show how **one action touches many parts** of people's lives in your project stories

4-5

Week 4-5: Design Thinking & Grant Writing

Explain the **system clearly to funders**: root causes, connections, risks, and why your approach makes sense

6

Week 6: Policy, Partnerships & Scaling

Point to **specific leverage points**, where one policy change could unlock many SDG wins



The Thread

The way you think about systems will **show up in every session**, from design to storytelling to policy engagement.

From problem → system → smarter strategy

Three Questions to Carry With You

1

What is really going on here?

Not just the **symptoms** we see, but the **structures underneath**

2

How are things connected?

Which **SDGs**, which **groups**, what **policies**, what **behaviours**?

3

Where is the smartest place to start?

Given limited resources, where can a **small action influence a larger system**?

Your Navigation Tool

If you leave today remembering only these **three questions** — and you use them whenever you design an initiative — you're already practicing systems thinking.

Write them down. Put them where you'll see them. Make them a habit.

“ **Remember:** Systems thinking is not about being complicated. It's about being **honest about how the world really works** .

Your community as a system

- ? What **surprised me** today about how things connect?
- ? Which **new questions** will I ask before jumping into solutions?
- ? Who else do I need to **talk to** to properly understand this system?

Systems thinking is not about being complicated. It's about being honest about how the world really works.

Carry that honesty into your SDG advocacy and projects — into the streets you clean, the policies you push, the stories you tell — and you will design work that **lasts longer, reaches deeper, and respects the real lives** of the people you're trying to serve.